

BRIAN MORMAN

Marketing and Consumer Focus - Case write-up - Dove

How did Dove's positioning change from the 1950s to when the case was written?

Dove's brand identity in the 1950's was tied to soap as a singular product. They emphasized one particular benefit of their soap in all advertising and highlighted its capabilities to prevent skin drying out. It successfully used that campaign for decades until the Unilever consolidation of brands into "Masterbrands" which asked the brand Dove to represent more than one product. It became a diverse portfolio of products that needed branding that could represent more than just one product. It changed from a single product to a group of products loosely tied together by a driving force and a singular point of view. Their research efforts ultimately lead to "The Campaign for Real Beauty". This strategy turned from talking about functional benefits of the brand to a view point of what the world is and how it should be. It became a spiritual campaign based more on what the product represents than what it does. It shifted its focus to the brand values more than the products features.

Spend some time searching to see what people are saying about Dove today.
What is your sense of the meaning of the brand in consumers' eyes?

The sentiment I found around the Dove brand are primarily positive. The general discourse does include praise about Dove's body positive messaging. There is still positive sentiment towards the product's skin friendly features. Dove does however face criticism of their brand for environmental purposes and a phenomenon called "pinkwashing". The environmental statements come from concerns from Greenpeace about plastic packaging waste from Dove's products. "Pinkwashing" is the concept that the Brand's body positive messaging and feminine friendly communications strategy is just that, a strategy without real substantial action to resolve the issues they are drawing attention to.